

Small ornithischians

The dinosaur family tree is split into two halves: saurischians and ornithischians. The ornithischians were plant-eaters with beaked jaws for plucking leaves and large bellies for digesting them. Though some ornithischians were huge, four-footed giants, many were small, two-footed herbivores that scurried about nervously in forests and scrublands, searching for food and trying to avoid predators.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Plant-eaters
- Beaked jaws
- Back-pointing pubis bone
- Large belly for digesting vegetation

When

Ornithischians lived from the beginning of the Jurassic Period, 200 million years ago, to the end of the Cretaceous Period, 65 million years ago.

Heterodontosaurus

HET-er-oh-DON-toe-SORE-us



- **When** 200–190 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** S. Africa
- **Habitat** Scrubland
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Plants, tubers, possibly insects

had large, fanglike teeth to defend itself against enemies. The jaws were tipped with a horny beak that was probably used for plucking leaves.

Unlike most dinosaurs, which had one type of tooth, *Heterodontosaurus* (“different-toothed lizard”) had three types. Its sharp front teeth snapped off tough vegetation, which was then mashed to a pulp with its cheek teeth. It also

◀ FOSSIL

Heterodontosaurus's complete skeleton was found in 1976 with every bone in place.

